Useful Resources

Lab and Assignment

Free sites and tools for building your website and social media content

Images

Gradients, cropping and resizing

Adding Gradients

CSS Gradient

Build a gradient and copy the CSS straight into your stylesheet
cssgradient.io

uiGradients

Ready-made gradient colour pairs to start from
uigradients.com

Cropping Images

Photopea

Free Photoshop-style editor that runs in the browser
photopea.com

Adobe Express

Quick crop to set shapes and aspect ratios
adobe.com/express

Image Resizing

BIRME

Resize and crop a whole batch of images to the exact same size
birme.net

Squoosh

Shrink file size and convert to WebP, with a before/after preview
squoosh.app

TinyPNG

Drag and drop to compress JPG, PNG and WebP files
tinypng.com

Tip Resize before you upload: about 1920px wide for full-width banners, about 1200px for gallery images, and aim for under 300 KB per image.

Images

Image resources

Free photos

Unsplash

High-quality free photos
unsplash.com

Pexels

Free photos and videos, searchable by colour and orientation
pexels.com

Pixabay

Free photos, illustrations and vectors
pixabay.com

Illustrations and icons

unDraw

Free illustrations you can recolour to match your palette
undraw.co

Bootstrap Icons

Free icon set that works with the Bootstrap labs
icons.getbootstrap.com

Tip Check the licence on every image, and keep a list of where each one came from for your submission.

Colour

Palettes, meaning and branding

Colour Palette Picker

Coolors
Press the spacebar to generate palettes; lock the colours you like
coolors.co

Adobe Color
Colour wheel with harmony rules, or pull a palette from a photo
color.adobe.com

Realtime Colors
Preview your colours and fonts on a real website layout
realtimecolors.com

About Colour psychology

Canva: colour meanings
What each colour tends to communicate
canva.com/learn/color-meanings

Colours and Branding

Help Scout: psychology of colour
How colour affects branding and marketing
helpscout.com/blog/psychology-of-color

BrandColors
The official colour codes of well-known brands
brandcolors.net

Other

WebAIM Contrast Checker
Check your text is readable on its background
webaim.org/resources/contrastchecker

Color Hunt
Browse palettes other designers have shared
colorhunt.co

Logo Design

Learn the basics, then make one

Learn how

Adobe Express: how to design a logo
Beginner's guide: logo types, colour, fonts, and testing your logo
adobe.com/express/learn/blog/how-to-design-a-logo

Make it

Canva logo maker
Free; start from a blank square rather than a template
canva.com/create/logos

Adobe Express logo maker
Free; simple shapes, icons and fonts in one place
adobe.com/express/create/logo

The five logo types

Wordmark
The business name in a chosen font

Lettermark
Just the initial or initials

Pictorial mark
A simple picture or icon

Combination mark
Icon and name together

Emblem
Name sitting inside a shape, like a badge

See examples of each on slide 7.

Tip Sketch three or four rough ideas on paper before you open any tool.

Make a Simple Logo

No design experience needed

1. **Write three words about the business**
   For example: friendly, local, fresh. Every choice you make next should match these words.

2. **Pick one simple idea**
   Either the first letter of the name, or one plain shape linked to what the business does (a cup, a leaf, a wheel).

3. **Choose one font**
   Pick a clean, readable font from Google Fonts for the name. Don't stretch or squash it.

4. **Choose one colour**
   Take one main colour from your site's palette, plus black or white. That's all you need.

5. **Build it and test it**
   Put it together in Canva or Adobe Express. Check it still works tiny (like a phone icon) and in plain black.

Do

- Keep it simple
- Use 1 or 2 colours
- Use 1 font
- Make sure it reads at a small size

Avoid

- Lots of tiny detail
- Gradients and shadows
- Stretched or squashed text
- More than two fonts
- Using a template as it comes

Simple Business Logos

What each type can look like (made-up businesses)

fernway.
PLANT SHOP

Wordmark
Just the name, in one font and colour

K
KILN STUDIO

Lettermark
The first letter inside a simple shape

Harbour
Coffee

Combination mark
A small icon next to the name

TIDY BIKES
EST. 2026

Emblem
Name and icon sitting inside a badge shape

BRICK & BEAM

Pictorial mark
One simple picture of what the business does

K
KILN STUDIO

K
KILN STUDIO

The one-colour test
A good logo still works in plain black or white

Formatting

Type, writing and checking your pages

Fonts and type

Google Fonts

Free web fonts with copy-and-paste embed code
fonts.google.com

Fontjoy

Generates heading and body font pairings
fontjoy.com

Typescale

Sets consistent sizes for h1 to h6 and body text
typescale.com

Writing for the web

Hemingway Editor

Highlights long sentences and hard-to-read text
hemingwayapp.com

GOV.UK: writing for the web

How people read online, and how to write for them
gov.uk/guidance/content-design

Check your pages

W3C Markup Validator

Finds errors in your HTML
validator.w3.org

WAVE

Checks a page for accessibility problems
wave.webaim.org

Tip Stick to two fonts at most: one for headings and one for body text.

Building the Site

Bootstrap, HTML and CSS help

Bootstrap

Bootstrap
Download and docs; the Navbar page is under Components
getbootstrap.com

HTML and CSS help

MDN Web Docs
The most reliable reference for HTML and CSS
developer.mozilla.org

W3Schools
Simple examples you can try out in the browser
w3schools.com

Layout

CSS-Tricks: guide to Flexbox
Visual guide to lining things up in rows and columns
css-tricks.com

Test it on mobile

Chrome DevTools device mode
Preview your site at phone and desktop sizes
developer.chrome.com/docs/devtools

Video

Footage, editing and adding video to a page

Free footage

Pexels Videos
Free stock video clips
pexels.com/videos

Pixabay Videos
Free stock video, including short loops
pixabay.com/videos

Coverr
Free clips designed for website backgrounds
coverr.co

Edit and compress

Clipchamp
Simple browser-based video editor
clipchamp.com

HandBrake
Free app to shrink video files for the web
handbrake.fr

Adding video to a page

MDN: the video element
How to put your own video file on a page
developer.mozilla.org

YouTube: embed a video
How to get the embed code for a YouTube video
support.google.com/youtube

Tip Export as MP4, keep clips short, and mute any video that plays automatically.

Audio

Music, sound effects and editing

Music

YouTube Audio Library

Free music and sound effects (sign in with a Google account)
youtube.com/audiolibrary

Uppbeat

Free music for creators; free accounts get 10 downloads a month
uppbeat.io

Pixabay Music

Free music tracks
pixabay.com/music

Sound effects

Freesound

Huge sound library; check each file's licence
freesound.org

Pixabay Sound Effects

Free sound effects
pixabay.com/sound-effects

Editing

Audacity

Free app to trim, fade and tidy up audio
audacityteam.org

Tip Credit the artist the way the licence asks, even when the track is free.

Social Media

Sizes, design and research for your report

Image sizes

Hootsuite: image sizes guide
Current sizes for every major platform
blog.hootsuite.com

Buffer: image sizes guide
Sizes for nine networks with diagrams
buffer.com/resources

Create posts

Canva
Templates sized for each platform
canva.com

Adobe Express
Quick social graphics and short videos
adobe.com/express

Research for your report

DataReportal
Social media statistics by country, including Ireland
datareportal.com

Meta Ad Library
See the ads any business is running on Facebook and Instagram
facebook.com/ads/library

Google Trends
See what people are searching for, and when
trends.google.com

User Personas

Who is your website and social media for?

Learn how

Nielsen Norman Group: personas
What a persona is and why it's useful
nngroup.com/articles/persona

Interaction Design Foundation: personas
Short guide to creating personas, with examples
interaction-design.org

Make one

Xtensio
Free persona template you fill in online, with a how-to guide
xtensio.com

Google Forms
Make a quick survey to collect real answers for your persona
forms.google.com

What to include

- A name and a photo (use a free stock photo)
- Age, job and where they live
- Goals: what they want to get done
- Frustrations: what gets in their way
- Which social media platforms they use, and when
- How they'd find and use the business
- A short quote in their own words

Tip Base your persona on real people: ask three to five possible customers a few questions first.

Competitor Analysis

How to do one in five steps

1. **Pick three competitors**
   Ideally one big brand, one local business and one about the same size as yours.

2. **Look at their websites**
   Note the menu, colours, fonts, tone of voice, what's on the home page, and how it works on a phone.

3. **Look at their social media**
   Which platforms, how often they post, and which posts get the most likes and comments.

4. **Compare them in a table**
   Use the same headings for every competitor so they are easy to compare.

5. **Spot the gaps**
   What do they all do well? What does nobody do? That gap is your opportunity.

Useful tools

Asana: competitive analysis template
A ready-made table layout to copy
asana.com/templates

Similarweb
Estimates a website's traffic and where visitors come from
similarweb.com

Social Blade
Follower and growth stats for social accounts
socialblade.com

Meta Ad Library
See the ads a competitor is running right now
facebook.com/ads/library

Wayback Machine
See how a competitor's website looked in the past
web.archive.org

Tip Take screenshots as you go: they are your evidence.